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Bluffing in Derado

by Burt Burlington

*“The universe is bigger than ever before,
but there is nothing to do.”*

Is this what death is like?

Darkness, nil stimuli reaching my senses. Opening my eyes, hoping I still had them, but the scenery didn't change. Blind, feelingless and immovable. It felt as if I was just a consciousness floating aimlessly in an unconscious universe. No stars, no planets, no people, no problems.

It was just me in this new universe. *But who was I? I know who I was, but what am I now?*

I was Jax, also known as “Kid Fury,” the gambler, infamous across the entire Virgo cluster region. Known for my aggressive playing style and my even more youthful attitude. I would host extravagant parties like the CEO of a Kolox mining company but would phone in my work as much as a first-year student at the University of Uranus, also known as the University of Your Anus, *not that original, we weren't trying to be, it just fitted*. I had a great time there. Sex with women, with men and species of whom I can't even pronounce the race,

let alone who most of the people in the solar system haven't ever seen, let alone have sex with one of their orifices. I was the king back then, and I was the king my whole life.

Was...

Parties were becoming to feel less exciting, and the ones which did were few and far between. The people were becoming to feel more like strangers, even though I always liked strangers, but in some weird way, I felt like the stranger. It was difficult to know which people were or weren't friends.

Maybe Esmerexa?

A door to my side opened, streaming in blinding light, burning my eyeballs. The pain was vicious, but the realization I still had eyeballs was exhilarating. My eyes were unable to close as if someone cut off my eyelids. Not because my curiosity got the best of me, I just wasn't physically able to. As hard as I was pushing my eyes shut, not a muscle in my body moved.

From complete blindness from darkness to total blindness from lightness. *Was I still in my body, but was I dead, still with my soul locked up in my body?*

My eyes adjusting, I saw that I was in the back of the trunk of a space sedan, and my body was folded neatly inside. No handcuffs, lasers, or even rope constricted me, yet I couldn't move. *Surely, I must be trapped and stuck in my body!*

Terrified, my brain commanded my muscles to thrash around, yet they wouldn't listen. Only, a single tear dropped from my frozen eyeball. If that was a tear due to my sadness, or a tear due to my eyes drying out, I do not know.

“khovaN, look, he's crying!” a muffled voice spoke from the light.

“Get him out, Yist,” another, more annoyed voice spoke.

Two large grey arms, equipped with horns around its two appendages, spooned me up with ease and dragged me to the light.

Falling into red sand, headfirst, my eyes were just able to look forward.

A rectangular hole was in front of me, dug into the blood-red earth. A nearby red star, lighted up the round asteroid.

“Give me the Paralaxer,. Yist.”

Then, out of nowhere, a shockwave shot through my entire body. It felt as if a body-shaped tree grew rapidly from my neck down, extending its branches all to my ten fingers and down to my ten toes. My lungs, not having to manually pump in air for I don't know how long, opened my airways violently. It felt as if I had drowned and gotten back to life, and this was the first time my airways were used again. It felt as if I was having a heart attack. I struggled to sit up, and I saw two legs crouching in front of me.

“You always make things so much harder than they have to be, Jax.”

I looked up, and it was a red, demon-like figure looking down at me. He was even redder than the red sand or sun. With his black suit, he looked like the Christian devil himself.

Coughing blood on the red sand due to the recently unused lungs, the demon continued: “You know this is my least favourite way to settle affairs.”

He grabbed my throat, not caring if my blood would ruin his perfectly manufactured suit and pulled me closer to his face. “But you just can't take responsibility.”

He dropped me back to the floor. Whom I presume to be Yist, pressing a large Deadfox revolver against my occiput.

Kneeling in front of a perfectly coffin-shaped hole on a lone asteroid, floating through space with a gun pressed against the back of my head. *I wasn't scared.*

“You could have just asked for the money khovaN,” I said.

I looked up at kohvaN who was looking down on me from the other side of the hole, with his back to his luxurious Space Suite Sedan. Tinted windows, coated with anti-matter paint to throw off Department of International Crime radars.

“Is that supposed to make me laugh, Jax!” the red demon said, most likely growing redder if his skin allowed him.

I snicker under my breath, looking down at the hole. I didn't fear it, it almost felt comforting.

“I don't appreciate your jokes, nor do appreciate your life, *Kid Fury*.”

He said, circling around me like Auridents stalk their prey, waiting to pounce you with their toxic gold teeth.

“You owe me 3.5 million zyphons, and your last deadline is in five days, yet I have yet to see a single zyphon added to my account.”

“Not a single zyphon, probably doing bad business”

“I can leave you in this hole right now, you're lucky I am an optimist and that I like money more than unnecessary killing.” The well-dressed demon leaned over to my ear and spoke, “but only by a little.”

“Understandable,” I said, “it's poker season and Trinity Plaza is booming with rookies and tourists looking to try their luck at my game.”

KhovaN's eyes, piercing me.

“There I can make the money I have into even more money.”

KhovaN's piercing eyes dissolve into smiling eyes.

“What money?” khovaN said with a badly hidden smile. “I took liberty in scavenging your Trinity Plaza hotel suite and my men found around 450.000 zyphons worth of jewellery, drugs and money.”

“What! That is easily around 1.4 zyphons!” I stood up, but the heavy hands that so gracefully lifted me from the trunk of the car pushed me back into the dirt. “How am I supposed to make your money back if I have no money to bet?”

“That I don't know, nor do I care. But don't worry, Jax, I will take the 450.000 off the 3.5 million.” khovaN smiled as if he wasn't short a 3.1 million. “But do I understand this correctly, Kid, you want to pay me back, or want to settle it here right now?”

I shook my head, looking over the short horizon of the asteroid. Sigh.

“I will get you the money.”

#

The planet Derado was a rare green rock-covered desert planet. If the people didn't come to the gambling hub, Trinity City, they would come to see the green canyons and sand hills the dwarf planet had to offer. Fittingly, the green marches reminded people of the dark green felt of the poker tables, making it the perfect spot for any gambling-crazed loser like me. It was the place I wanted to go to from a time before I was a Uranus Alumni *if I ever graduated that is*. I played poker during the breaks and would be playing semi-professionally during the lectures. Never attending classes will give you enough time to become good at something. And good I became, very good.

I set my sights on the green-forsaken desert planet of Derado. A planet that felt like it was made specially for me by God himself, with booze, gambling and prostitutes. And never did I question that godsent.

Tourists from around the galaxies, with their ancient Earthly Hawai'ian shirts, walked the streets of Trinity City. Taking pictures of the green mountains in the distance, the expensive hovering Space Suites going up and down the Trinity strip, and the even more colourful alien street performers dressed up like infamous characters like Blorgus the Blorgian, Your Neighbourhood friendly Traxton, and Spiderman.

The host stars, Voxis and Deimos were both close to going down, meaning the *real* gambling that went on in Trinity City would start. Chips would be pushed aside in the hope of real money. Cash is one thing, putting lives on the line is another thing. Instead of putting old-fashioned chips on the line, you could just put your life, your organs, or even your

children's organs on the line. Derado is the place to make money, the life of a simple human is worth 1.000.000 zyphons, that's all I am saying.

A flock of squishy Flurries were taking pictures with their cyborg eye lenses of random by-passers and Spiderman, until the black Space Suite hovercraft parked beside them.

I got thrown outside the car onto the pavement on the Trinity strip, still covered in red mud on my white suit. KohvaN's black hovercraft raced off and left me on the sidewalk in front of the Trinity Plaza hotel. The Flurries turned to me and started taking pictures of me as if I was a bad rendition of "Slippery Snooxie." But when they realized I was merely a human and not a real Roxiod, they turned their attention away from me.

Voxis was completely hidden behind the curvature of Derado, while Deimos peeked its little red top over it. The trillions of neon lights that would keep Trinity City in a constant limbo between life and death were some of the smaller things I enjoyed in life, but not anymore.

Sitting on the side of the road, looking at the vast array of hovercrafts whooshing by, I tried thinking of a way to pay my debts to khovaN.

I could not care.

I couldn't really care whatever he wanted or whatever he would do if I didn't cooperate. I looked at the unremovable red stains on my favourite white 200.000 zyphon suit, of which too, I couldn't care less about.

I heard the sounds of heels clicking on the pavement behind me. Heels on the strip were like the howl of a wolf in a forest. Still, I had an inkling to whom this howl belonged. A tap on my shoulder followed.

"Looking for a girlfriend, sugar?"

"Not now Esmerexa," I said annoyed looking at the ground in front of me.

"You're not looking for a good time?"

"I don't have any money on me right now, Rexa."

“Oh baby, you know I ain't looking for that.”

She sat down beside me, a fine-looking scaly reptilian Trecko female. She was wearing pink human high-heels that weren't designed for her muscular Trecko feet.

But goddamn she knows I found them sexy, and so did everybody on the Trinity strip.

Her long backward knees crouched down beside me, sitting next to me on the sidewalk. Her short skirt shows all her means of income to the people on the other side of the strip.

“What is it, baby?”

“Just some family issues.”

“Family? I didn't know you had any family.”

I snickered. I never talked about family with her, nor was I the person that looked like I could give a damn about family.

“It's nothing, Rexa, just hungover.”

“Baby you straight up lying in my face, you never are hungover at high-noon poker night, that is even too stupid for a stupid person like you.”

I smiled. *This woman knows me too well.* Looking up at her, she was a head higher than me and had these huge yellowy eyes in which I could clearly see my own reflection, amazingly hot, can't recommend it enough.

“Let's go to my room.”

“That's what I'm trying to tell you.” she laughed.

Walking through the hallway, we made our way to my room. The doors weren't closed. I got scared for a second, not knowing what could've happened, but then I remembered khovaN's men plundered it when they paralaxed me.

We stepped inside and were greeted by a torn op mattress, thrown over 0and cabinets, and a plundered walk-in closet.

"Sorry for the mess," I throw my keys on the tipped-over dresser where I normally threw my keys.

"Nothing new, your bed is always a mess."

We both laughed.

I went to the suite tablet installed on the wall, but the screen was busted.

"I'm sorry, Rex, no music or mood lighting."

Esmerexa looks over her shoulder when she was taking off her pink stripper shoes.

"Huh, oh, no problem."

Rummaging through my many suits in the closed, I found my collection of exclusive Sescentipede Cigars, 500 zyphons per smoke. Lighting my cigar with the automatic lighter robot arm at the side of the bed, I laid down on the covers. I blew up purple smoke, and from the smoke plume, Esmerexa's face appeared. She kissed me. I felt the saliva titillating on my lips. She crawled down to my legs, taking off my shoes slowly.

"How can it be you have no money, and who thrashed up the place?"

I looked down at her, forming my double chin. I blew a large purple cloud from my mouth.

"Have you loaned money again?" She stopped unzipping my pants and sat down on my legs. She looked down at me with a worried look.

All I could respond with was by looking away and taking a big drag from my cigar, but my answer was loud and clear.

"How much was it?"

"3.5," I responded, looking at the tipped-over dresser. I felt her disappointed stare, burning into the side of my head.

It felt like an eternity. My cigar probably was 2 inches shorter than when I first answered. I looked back at her. And of course, her eyes were as big as those of a puppy, and

her eyebrows and mouth were curled all the way down. My chest grew cold and empty, as if there was nothing inside of me at all, emotionally or physically.

“I'm worried about you.”

The emptiness I felt became infinitely deeper, with the floor of the emptiness falling all the way down to non-existence. My eyes filled with tears.

“I'm... I'm... I'm just so sor- I just can't, I just don't know.” The crying took away my ability to speak.

"Oh, baby," Rexa bent forward and laid on top of me, hugging me tightly as a way of holding me together.

We lay there, my quick breathing slowed down after a minute or two, and after another few minutes, our breathing synched up.

She pushed her head closer to my ear and whispered, “you can get out of this, you're Kid Fury, one of the best poker players the galaxy got.”

Emptiness in my voice, “that is not what I am worried about.”

Esmerexa lifted her head and looked at me. “Then what is it?”

“I don't care if they kill me.”

I said, staring into Rexa's frozen yellow eyes.